INTERVIEW

KAMAL KISHORE

"Long-endurance submarines pose new challenges"



In December 2021, **Admiral Hari Kumar** *took over as Navy chief at a time when the service is under increasing budgetary pressure and a lengthening border standoff with China has taken attention away from India's maritime frontiers. In a series of written responses to* **Managing Editor Sandeep Unnithan**, *he outlines the priorities of the world's fifth largest navy, particularly relating to the introduction of Chinese submarines in the Indian Ocean. Excerpts*:

Q. With the Indian maritime theatre command coming up by 2023, will you be the first Navy chief not to have direct operational command?
Theaterisation is the most suitable way to enhance joint application of force. Studies to finalise the nuances are being undertaken by C-in-C level officers with participation from all three services. The roles of the service chiefs, theatre commanders, etc., would be finalised after this.

Q. India has a 3,448 km contested land boundary with China and 740 km with Pakistan. It has no maritime disputes with China. How much of a factor will this be when it comes to budgetary allocations?
There is a growing acceptance that the maritime domain will be a prime facilitator of our economic growth. The role and responsibility of the Indian Navy to protect our maritime interests is, therefore, likely to grow. The Indian Navy remains committed to maintaining a high level of operational preparedness and progress of its modernisation plans, within the available financial resources.

Q. What steps is the Navy taking to boost ASW (anti-submarine warfare) training?
The technological advancements and growing complexities in the subsurface domain entail a due impetus on ASW. Training our personnel in the latest technological developments whilst keeping abreast with contemporary weapons/sensors has been a key focus area for the Indian Navy. The advent of long-endurance submarines equipped with enhanced stealth features operating in complex environmental conditions have posed new challenges in the underwater domain.

Q. What will the Navy's priorities be under the CDS's new ICADS (integrated capability development plan)?
The Indian Navy remains focussed on creating a balanced, multi-dimensional and networked force in the long term. While ships, submarines and aircraft are being inducted apace, the Navy would also be focusing on the induction of long range sensors and weapons with precision strike capability. Unmanned and autonomous vehicles and new age weapons and sensors would be part of our capability in the future.

Q. Does the renewed thrust on SSNs (nuclear attack submarines) worldwide alter your case for the indigenous SSNs in any way?
SSNs possess excellent mobility and endurance with enormous combat potential. The recent developments worldwide only reinforce the importance of the SSN as a versatile platform that would be desired by any navy in the world. ■